

What's one thing most people get completely wrong about agriculture—and what's the real dairy story?

“Agriculture is the most healthful, most useful, and most noble employment of man.”

Amanda Zigan quoted George Washington while giving me a tour of her dairy farm this summer. I didn't question the claim for a second. I didn't need to, because growing up on a crop farm, I've seen firsthand the work farming demands and have nothing but respect for people who do it.

Still, in today's world, some people see agriculture as just another job with long hours and a way to make a living. Some assume it's old-fashioned or even harmful to the environment. But what they miss is that farming isn't just a job. It's a life, a calling, and a commitment that doesn't end when the sun goes down, or even when the harvest, planting, or calving season is over.

Farmers don't punch in, and there's no “leaving work at work” when your “office” is the view outside your kitchen window. For many of us, the farm is not only our livelihood, it's our home, our history, and our legacy. My dad started our crop farm from the ground up, God rest his soul, and my mom fought to keep it alive. Now, 20 years later, I am proud to watch my older brother carry that work forward.

In a world of unpredictable weather, shifting markets, and machinery that always seems to break at the worst possible time, there is immense pride beneath the stress. Yet I wouldn't trade growing up on a farm for anything. It's the kind of life that leaves a mark and teaches you how to show up even when you're exhausted. It reminds you every day of what truly matters.

And dairy farming? That takes everything crop farming does, and then some. The cows don't stop needing food, water, or care just because it's Christmas or 20 below outside. Farmers work through holidays, storms, and even burnout, not for praise, but because their farm depends on them.

That's the part most people never see. They don't see the dedication. The science behind feed rations, the constant adaptation, the investments in technology, sustainability, and animal welfare.

I'll never forget the emotion I felt on the Zigan family farm, that quiet but powerful emotion when you realize you're part of something bigger than yourself. To wake up knowing that so much is dependent on you. Farming is rooted in land, blood, sweat, and hope. It's not just employment, it's a purpose.

That's the real story people miss about agriculture. It's not just about the food or money (and, more often than not, doing so with slim margins). It's about people, real families, working hard and often silently, to keep the rest of the world going.

So yes, George Washington was right. Agriculture is the most noble employment. I learned that truth growing up on the farm my dad built, and I heard it again in the quiet voice of a dairy farmer who lives it every single day.